DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

When Is No Punishment the Worst Punishment?

Daat Tevunot §142-146

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §142-146
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 3 July 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Judgment held in the background

The recording begins partway through the end of §142. The Ramhal describes a time when it is as if God has left the world and takes no interest in what people do. Then it is said that there is no judgment at all. It exists only in potential, held in the background. Why keep it at all? Because out of His love, Hashem is still watching for when He can bring it back and lead the world to its betterment.

A participant asked whether people "got away with it" in the first 2,000 years. The Rabbi went back to the example of the ignored pupil. Nothing happens to him now, but he will pay for it for the rest of his life. One kind of punishment says "I care about you, so here is a detention". The other kind says "I'm ignoring you", and that is the worst.

The Neshamah's challenge

In §143-145 the Neshamah objects: "Don't hold back either way." Either Hashem runs the world with kindness, in which case there should be no bad, or He runs it with justice, in which case all the chaos is a result of judgment. Besides, you said yourself that hester comes because of sin, and that is judgment. So how can you say judgment is concealed?

Two kinds of hester

The Sekhel answers (§146) that all good and bad come from revelation or concealment, but there are two kinds of concealment:

1. **Concealment without judgment.** Evil is allowed to build and rule, with nothing to cleanse it. This is the greatest hester.
2. **Concealment with judgment.** The world is still in hester, and Hashem is not acting through kindness and teshuvah, but He is punishing according to strict judgment, so sins are being cleansed. This is bad, but relatively it is good, because it is "concealment with rectification".

The Rabbi brought the Gemara on the verse about lashes: once a sinner has been punished, "he is your brother" again. Punishment cleanses. In the worst hester there is no such cleansing. "It's paradoxical: the greater the hester, the less involvement of God, and the less punishment

there is." He gave a school example: being kept behind by a caring teacher, being given lines or detention, and being ignored while the class falls apart. The last is the worst.

The first 2,000 years

This greatest hester was the first 2,000 years, the period the Gemara calls tohu, chaos. The Rabbi pointed out that the Torah covers that whole period in two parashiyot: Adam, Noah and Bavel. Avraham was born in the year 1948, so the 2,000 years run roughly up to Avraham, and the Ramhal seems to count until the exodus from Egypt. There were moments of judgment, like the Flood, but they were few.

Asked whether people then received karet or Gehinnom, the Rabbi said, "I don't think anyone can answer the question." Asked how they could be held responsible without the Torah, he answered that there was a basic morality. Kayin was punished for killing Hevel, and the Flood came mainly because of theft, so people evidently knew that killing and stealing were wrong.

He contrasted this with the book of Bemidbar, where every failing of the Jews in the wilderness brings an immediate consequence. That is also hester, but with direct judgment.

Even in the deepest hester

The Ramhal adds that even in the greatest concealment Hashem never leaves the world completely. He is always thinking about how to bring it to its tikkun. He brings the Midrash on Yaakov's complaint, "Why did you do me harm?", when his sons said the viceroy wanted Binyamin. Rabbi Levi said Yaakov never said anything so mistaken. At that very moment Hashem was making Yosef king so that Yaakov could live out his days in peace. "My way is hidden from Hashem," says Yeshayahu. Yaakov saw only the pain.

The lesson: any elevation Hashem brings often comes by a roundabout way, through pain first. Hazal say three gifts were given to Israel only through suffering, and one of them is Eres Yisrael. "Look in our days," said the Rabbi.

Stages two and three

The Ramhal then lists further levels of judgment, which the Rabbi stressed are not in chronological order:

- **Level 2: now,** after the Temple. There are no prophets or miracles, but there is more knowledge of God than in the time of tohu. We have the Torah forever, and God's name is known among the nations. The Rabbi noted that more than half the world's population belong to faiths that trace back to Avraham. Most of them believe in one God, unlike the idol worship of the first 2,000 years.
- **Level 3: the time of the Temples,** when Hashem ruled openly with miracles. But this is only an external revelation. Without the miracles, faith would not be clear.

Level 4, the inner knowledge of Har Sinai, was left for the next class. The Rabbi admitted he had gone "very fast" and promised to go over it again.

Summary

- Judgment can be held in the background, in potential only, while Hashem waits for the right time to bring it back.
- There are two kinds of hester: with judgment, which cleanses, and without judgment, which lets evil build up. The second is far worse.
- The first 2,000 years were the time of the deepest hester. Even then there was some basic morality and occasional judgment.
- Even in the deepest hester, Hashem is working towards the tikkun, as with Yaakov and Yosef. Good often comes through pain first.
- The levels of revealed judgment are not chronological: now (Torah but no miracles), then the Temple era (external miracles).

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